Steven Wilssens

Product leader who invents new products, using data, experimentation and AI as tools

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LOOKING FOR
Product leadership roles building new products, where data, experimentation and AI are tools rather than the job · available now

SCOPE
Led teams of 10 to 20 product managers; telemetry from 1.6B+ Windows devices

BACKGROUND
Product leader since 2008, software engineer and team lead before that

SUMMARY

Product leader with nearly 20 years at Microsoft who sees early where customers and markets are heading, and builds for it: choosing low latency over 4K as the differentiator for xCloud game streaming, forecasting how a key Windows AI feature would land in retail well before broad rollout, and inventing products in areas I was new to, from spatial audio for Windows and Xbox to the data and experimentation systems that decide what ships on more than 1.6 billion Windows devices. Co-inventor on 19 granted US patents spanning spatial audio, game streaming, casting and device telemetry. I lead teams of 10 to 20 product managers, use data, experimentation and AI to find what works, and keep building products myself.

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

250%+
growth in monthly active spatial-audio devices

1.6B+
Windows devices informing product decisions

+5%
Perfect Day improvement for Windows gaming

~30%
fewer issue days across Perfect Day scenarios

SKILLS

New product invention, from zero to one · Product strategy and roadmaps · Platform and game partnerships (Dolby, DTS, Netflix, Disney+, Halo, Forza Horizon, Gears of War, Call of Duty) · Data platforms, experimentation and A/B testing · AI and machine learning products · Hands-on AI product building (Claude Code, MCP, Cloudflare) · Leading PM organizations of 10 to 20, including managers of managers · Executive communication · Software engineering background (C#, .NET)

EXPERIENCE

Oct 2026 - Present

Independent AI Product Builder

Independent · Seattle, Washington

Building AI products independently after Microsoft.

- Building AI Breaker (aibreaker.org), a Windows app that lets people turn off AI features in graduated levels.
- Built a multi-tenant hosting and email platform with MCP-based AI apps in 16 days (wilssens.com): isolated server code and database per site, automated mailbox provisioning, and every action available on the web, over MCP and from a command line.
- Runs juniortrackcycling.com, a content and analytics site for the junior track cycling community.

Dec 2024 - Sep 2026

Principal Group Product Manager - Windows & Devices Data

Microsoft · Redmond, Washington

Led product management for the entire Windows & Devices Data organization: the data, insights, experimentation, and machine learning models that power decision-making across Windows and Devices.

- Led a PM organization of about 20, working with more than 100 developers and data scientists, initially through three people managers, then led its move to a flatter team of about 12 during Microsoft's cost reductions; roughly half the team was promoted under my leadership.
- Owned strategy and roadmap for the data platform and insights products Windows engineers and PMs use to ship higher-quality releases.
- Built the quality measurement framework that underpinned Windows K2, Microsoft's high-profile push to improve Windows reliability and performance.
- Ran the weekly ship-readiness quality review where Windows VPs made release decisions based on my team's data on ship-blocking issues.
- Scaled experimentation across Windows to hundreds of concurrent experiments, significantly reducing the number of features pulled back after release.

- Owned the multi-million-dollar Windows data infrastructure budget; shut down a low-adoption on-device model platform and reinvested in platform modernization, cutting costs 30% over two years.
- Shifted the team to AI-driven analytics and launched the first version, letting people ask business questions in natural language across every source in the data platform instead of relying on fixed queries.
- Partnered with engineering, data science, and research leadership across telemetry from more than 1.6 billion Windows devices.

Feb 2020 - Dec 2024

Principal Product Manager Lead - Windows Data

Microsoft · Redmond, Washington

Built data products that told the story of the Windows customer experience and informed continuous improvement.

- Redefined Windows quality measurement around end-to-end scenarios like gaming and the shell, creating the Perfect Day metric for issue-free user days.

Sep 2019 - Feb 2020

Principal Product Manager Lead - Azure DevOps

Microsoft · Redmond, Washington

Defined new products, go-to-market strategies, and business decisions for the Azure DevOps Platform.

- Defined DataOps as its sole product lead: a startup-style project inside Azure DevOps before it had a funded team, writing the product proposal that got it funded and moved to GitHub as its better home.

Jan 2018 - Sep 2019

Principal Product Manager Lead - Silicon, Graphics, Media

Microsoft · Redmond, Washington

Led audio, spatial audio, game streaming, xCloud, Game DVR, broadcast, and casting initiatives.

- Led six PMs, working with about 20 developers.

Sep 2017 - Jan 2018

Principal Product Manager - Silicon, Graphics, Media

Microsoft · Redmond, Washington

Drove the Windows Sonic spatial audio platform for Windows and Xbox One while representing Microsoft at developer and game conferences.

- Drove the launch of Dolby Access v3 and DTS Sound Unbound with new app services, licensing, and customization models.

Oct 2008 - Aug 2017

Senior Product Manager - Silicon, Graphics, Media

Microsoft · Redmond, Washington

Led media platform work across casting, conferencing and spatial audio, culminating in the Spatial Audio Platform and Windows Sonic for Windows and Xbox One.

- Brought casting to Windows and Windows Phone, shipping Miracast, DLNA and Play To so people could send media from a PC or phone to a TV.

Oct 2006 - Sep 2008

Product Manager - Developer Division

Microsoft · Redmond, Washington

Product manager in Microsoft's Developer Division working on developer ecosystem and community products.

- Launched the Visual Studio Marketplace, giving developers one place to find and share Visual Studio extensions.

EARLIER CAREER · BELGIUM

Jan 2006 - Sep 2006 — **Lead Developer and Team Lead**, Compuware · Belgium
Led a team of about 15 developers and the Project Support Office for Fluxys.

Jan 2005 - Dec 2005 — **Software Developer**, Cosmos · Antwerp Area, Belgium
Built and supported software components across C# client and Java server systems using CORBA middleware. Joined as a consultant from Info Support, then hired full-time.

Jan 2001 - Dec 2004 — **Developer and Trainer**, Info Support · Belgium
Developed distributed .NET applications and trained teams across multiple organizations.

EDUCATION

Bachelor's degree, Computer Science
Karel de Grote, Belgium · 2000 - 2004

Languages
Dutch and English (native), French (intermediate)

HONORS

Selected for Microsoft's High Potential (HiPo) program · Lighthouse Award for Teamwork (2012) · Compass Award for Individual Excellence (2011) · Gold Star Award (2011) · Microsoft MVP: VS Team System (2006)

PATENTS AND PRESS

19 granted US patents, 7 published applications
Spatial audio, streaming, media and device telemetry (Microsoft). Press: Forbes, Windows Central; Build 2016 speaker.
steven.wilssens.com/patents